

Design Document for:

The Eldritch Darkness

[Ben Howell, Kyle Watson, Lorien Clark]

[07/24/26]

Table of Contents

NAME OF GAME	1
TABLE OF CONTENTS	2-3
GAME OVERVIEW	4
DESIGN PHILOSOPHY	4
GAME DESIGN GOALS	4
<i>Game Design Goal #1</i>	4
<i>Game Design Goal #2</i>	4
<i>Game Design Goal #3</i>	4
COMMON QUESTIONS	5
<i>What is the game?</i>	5
<i>Why create this game?</i>	5
<i>Where does the game take place?</i>	5
<i>What do I control?</i>	5
<i>How many characters do I control?</i>	5
<i>What is the main focus?</i>	5
<i>What's different?</i>	5
FEATURE SET	6
GENERAL FEATURES	6
MULTI-PLAYER FEATURES	6
EDITOR	6
GAME PLAY	6
THE GAME WORLD	7
OVERVIEW	7
WORLD FEATURE #1	7
WORLD FEATURE #2	7
THE PHYSICAL WORLD	8
<i>Overview</i>	8
<i>Key Locations</i>	8
<i>Travel</i>	9
<i>Scale</i>	9
<i>Objects</i>	9
<i>Weather</i>	9
<i>Day and Night</i>	9
<i>Time</i>	9
THE WORLD LAYOUT	10
OVERVIEW	10
WORLD LAYOUT DETAIL #1	10
WORLD LAYOUT DETAIL #2	10
GAME CHARACTERS	11
OVERVIEW	11
CREATING A CHARACTER	12
ENEMIES AND MONSTERS	12
USER INTERFACE	13
OVERVIEW	13
USER INTERFACE DETAIL #1	13

USER INTERFACE DETAIL #2	13
ITEMS	14
OVERVIEW	14
ITEMS DETAILS #1	14
ITEMS DETAILS #2	14
MUSICAL SCORES AND SOUND EFFECTS	15
OVERVIEW	15
RED BOOK AUDIO	15
3D SOUND	15
SOUND DESIGN	15
SINGLE PLAYER GAME	16
OVERVIEW	16
SINGLE PLAYER GAME DETAIL #1	16
SINGLE PLAYER GAME DETAIL #2	16
STORY	17
HOURS OF GAME-PLAY	17
VICTORY CONDITIONS	17
CHARACTER RENDERING	18
OVERVIEW	18
CHARACTER RENDERING DETAIL #1	18
CHARACTER RENDERING DETAIL #2	18
ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY	19
SOURCES AND NOTES	19

Game Overview

Design Philosophy

Vision Statement

The Eldritch Darkness is an atmospheric, audio-first detective mystery that combines psychological horror, noir storytelling, and accessibility-focused game design. Players step into the role of a visually impaired detective investigating the mysterious murder of Ashley Stern within the rain-soaked city of Ravenwatch, where humans and eldritch beings coexist under an uneasy peace.

Unlike traditional detective games that rely heavily on visual observation, *The Eldritch Darkness* challenges players to solve crimes using sound, intuition, environmental narration, and careful interviews. Every mechanic has been designed with accessibility in mind, allowing visually impaired and sighted players to experience the same mystery through different methods of perception.

As the investigation progresses, players discover that Ashley's murder is only one piece of a much larger conspiracy involving cosmic entities, corrupt organizations, and ancient forces hidden behind the city's perpetual fog. The deeper players investigate, the more they must question not only the people around them, but the reality they experience.

Game Design Goals

Goal #1: Accessibility Without Compromise

The Eldritch Darkness is trying to demonstrate to players what it would be like to be visually impaired while they solve a murder mystery involving eerie monsters. Accessibility is the foundation of *The Eldritch Darkness*, not an optional feature. Every aspect of gameplay, from movement and exploration to menus and investigations, is designed so visually impaired players can complete the game independently using audio narration, spatial sound, controller vibration, and optional voice controls. Rather than simplifying gameplay, the design creates equal experiences for all players regardless of visual ability.

Goal #2: Build Atmosphere Through Sound

This game will be completely playable for the visually impaired by making the game rely heavily on audio cues. For those that can see, it will simulate near blindness by allowing the player to only see vague and dark outlines of the monsters they are interviewing. Rain echoes through alleyways, footsteps reveal unseen movement, distant whispers hint at supernatural activity, and every character possesses a recognizable voice. Audio is not simply background ambience. It becomes the player's greatest investigative resource.

Goal #3: Create an Immersive Detective Experience

In addition to simulating visual impairment, this game will strive to provide an engaging mystery as the player finds clues using audio cues and attempts to glean information by conducting interviews with suspects and witnesses. The game will provide further clues through the character's tone of voice and heartbeat. Players should feel like real investigators. Rather than solving puzzles through highlighted objects or obvious clues, they must gather testimony, compare evidence, analyze inconsistencies, and build logical conclusions. Every interview, crime scene, and discovered document contributes to the larger investigation, rewarding careful observation and critical thinking.

Common Questions

What is the game?

The Eldritch Darkness is a murder mystery story based game that features a player designed detective that is visually impaired. The game will rely heavily on audio. It is meant to not only help players understand what it is like to be visually impaired, but be playable by the visually impaired. A woman named Ashley Stern has been found dead in her apartment. Players will interview neighbors and suspects and search for clues in a world where eldritch “monsters” live alongside human beings. Can you solve this mystery with the help of your partner seeing eye dog, Fuzzy?

Why create this game?

There is a major gap in the market for games that are accessible to the visually impaired. This game will be completely accessible to visually impaired players. They will be able to play with a controller, headset, and optionally use a mic for further input control. Visually impaired players will even be able to design their own characters using the mic to describe their character or using a system that reads each choice to the player to help them select their inputs for each section of character creation. This game also addresses a gap in the market to help able bodied players understand what it might be like to be blind. Visually able players will have very limited vision within the game, being only able to see vague shapes and outlines.

Where does the game take place?

The story unfolds within Ravenwatch, a sprawling noir metropolis permanently covered in rain and fog. Hidden beneath its ordinary streets lies a growing eldritch influence that slowly distorts reality. Although the investigation begins inside Ashley Stern's apartment building, players gradually explore police stations, abandoned subway tunnels, wealthy districts, forgotten archives, and hidden cult hideouts as the mystery expands.

What do I control?

The player controls a detective of their own creation, with help of their seeing eye dog. While movement, interviews, evidence collection, and decision-making are controlled directly by the player, the companion provides assistance through navigation, warning signals, and environmental awareness.

How many characters do I control?

The player only controls their player created detective.

What is the main focus?

The main focus of the game is to find the murderer of Ashley Stern, by investigating the crime scene and interviewing witnesses, neighbors, and suspects. Along the way, players uncover hidden conspiracies, earn the trust of witnesses, collect evidence, and determine whether the murder was motivated by ordinary human greed or something far more supernatural.

What's different?

This game is different from traditional murder mystery games in that it is designed to be accessible by the visually impaired, and help able players to understand what it might be like to be visually impaired. It is different from games such as *Blind Simulator* because it has clear objectives and a full storyline, does not require VR, and is designed to also be playable by players with actual visual impairment. Players rely on hearing instead of sight, spatial audio replaces visual indicators, and every investigation emphasizes observation, dialogue, and logical deduction over combat. Combined with randomized suspects, multiple endings, and immersive world-building, each playthrough offers a unique mystery while remaining approachable to players of varying abilities.

Feature Set

General Features

Game world: Intricate settings that can only be seen as vague shapes and outlines. The world will be vividly described using narration.

Visuals: As the game is meant to simulate visual impairment, the visuals will be highly limited to vague shapes of buildings, settings, and characters. One can see a dark silhouette of the highrise apartment building where the murder took place as they approach, and obscure outlines of the characters they interview.

Audio: The game's audio will feature robust 7.1 surround sound with spatial audio using Dolby Atmos and 3D emitters.

Control: The game will be designed to use a controller to interact with the game world.

Gameplay

Narration: The game will feature deeply detailed audio narration to describe scenes, settings, and characters. The objective is for the game to be completely playable using narration and audio cues.

Navigation: The player will be able to walk around and use a cane to interact with objects in front of them. The rumble feature on the controller will be used to warn players if they are about to walk into an object, with rumble intensifying as they approach an object.

Gameplay Loop: The game will feature the character moving around and interacting with people and objects to obtain clues in a limited, controlled environment. Players will be able to conduct interviews by selecting different lines of questions using audio aids and a controller. Players will be able to examine objects closely using narrated descriptions, and search multiple environments for different clues.

Story: The game will feature 5+ different storylines. The storyline will be automatically generated upon player creation. If a player has already completed one storyline with a specific character being found to be the perpetrator of the murder, then on their next playthrough the game will eliminate completed storylines as an option. This is meant to offer replayability to the game, and allow for further mystery solving even if the game has been completed before.

Companions: The player will be able to select an animal companion at the beginning of the game, with options spanning from a seeing eye dog to an eldritch creature that fulfills a similar function.

The Game World

Overview

The Eldritch Darkness is set within a city called Ravenwatch, a rain-slicked metropolis stuck in a perpetual 1940's twilight and anchored near a tear in the cosmic veil. Within this city, your classic Noir tropes meet the weird and strange realm of occult & Eldritch horror. Creatures of pure imagination and people changed and twisted by the ongoing influence walk the streets among normal people. As players investigate Ashley Stern's murder, they discover that Ravenwatch is more than an ordinary city—it is a place where secrets, corruption, and supernatural horrors exist just beneath the surface.

The Veil

The city of Ravenwatch is cloaked in a seemingly permanent fog, caused by the bleedthrough effect of being so close to a cosmic rift. This is known as “The Veil” by the locals, rolling off the bay area and carrying a faint violet haze. Many people say that if you wander within the fog for too long without purpose, something else will find you one. While most citizens have learned to live alongside it, prolonged exposure can alter perception, distort reality, and affect a person's mental state. Investigators often enter Veil-affected areas while searching for evidence, making each crime scene both physically and psychologically dangerous.

- **Sanity Mechanics:** Spending too much time within Veil-covered areas gradually lowers the detective's sanity. As sanity decreases, environmental sounds become distorted, silhouettes become less reliable, and false clues may begin to appear.
- **Environmental Hazards:** Thick fog limits navigation and can hide obstacles, unstable structures, or hostile creatures. Players must rely on their companion and spatial audio to safely investigate these dangerous locations.
- **Reality Distortion:** In areas with strong Veil influence, hallways may appear longer than they should, rooms may shift unexpectedly, and sounds may originate from impossible directions, creating uncertainty throughout the investigation.

Corruption Beneath the Surface

Although Ravenwatch appears to function like any other city, corruption exists at every level of society. Organized crime families, corrupt police officers, wealthy secret societies, and eldritch cults all compete for influence while hiding their activities from the general public. Many individuals have formed dangerous pacts with cosmic entities in exchange for power, wealth, or knowledge.

- **Black Market:** The city's underground economy extends far beyond ordinary crime. Smugglers traffic forbidden artifacts, cursed relics, occult manuscripts, and mysterious materials such as Warping Glass, a substance believed to absorb the influence of The Veil. These illegal items often become important pieces of evidence throughout the investigation and may reveal deeper connections between Ashley Stern's murder and Ravenwatch's hidden history.
- **Factions:** Several factions operate throughout Ravenwatch, each with its own goals and secrets. Some seek to protect humanity from the influence of The Veil, while others embrace eldritch powers for personal gain. During the investigation, players will encounter these groups through interviews, hidden locations, and optional side investigations. The relationships players build with certain factions may unlock additional information, alter dialogue, or influence the outcome of the story.

The Physical World

Overview

The physical world of *The Eldritch Darkness* is a claustrophobic, oppressive urban labyrinth designated to evoke isolation and dread. Ravenwatch is constructed from classic 1930's - 1950's architecture (Art deco skyscrapers, dimly lit brownstones, rusted fire escapes, aging apartment buildings, jazz clubs, smoke-filled police stations, and the like) twisted by non-euclidean geometry and cosmic decay. The environment isn't static, changing and warping as the cosmic influence bleeds into the surrounding area and creates shifting room layouts and unique structural decay that reveals more than what should be known. Beneath this ordinary appearance lies The Veil, an ancient supernatural force that conceals the city's true nature. As the detective investigates Ashley Stern's murder and spends more time within Veil-infected locations, their perception slowly changes. Familiar streets begin to warp, buildings seem larger than before, and the people around them gradually reveal monstrous eldritch forms that had been hidden all along. Voices become layered with unnatural whispers, reflections move independently, and reality itself becomes increasingly unreliable.

The city has not changed—the detective is simply beginning to see the truth.

Key Locations

- **Ashley Stern's Apartment:** The investigation begins inside Ashley Stern's apartment, where an apparent homicide quickly reveals signs of something much stranger. Hidden journal entries, damaged photographs, unusual symbols, and missing evidence suggest Ashley had uncovered a dangerous secret shortly before her death. As the detective revisits the apartment throughout the game, new details become noticeable as their perception changes, revealing clues that were hidden in plain sight.
- **Bluewater Bay and Docks:** Bluewater Bay serves as Ravenwatch's primary shipping district, where heavy fog and the constant sound of crashing waves create an unsettling atmosphere. Beneath the cover of legitimate shipping operations, smugglers transport eldritch artifacts, forbidden manuscripts, and mysterious materials connected to The Veil. Ashley's investigation uncovered records linking the docks to several missing persons cases, making this one of the detective's earliest leads. As The Veil's influence grows, dock workers begin revealing distorted voices and monstrous forms hidden beneath their human appearances.
- **The Blackiron District:** The soot-choked aging-industrial center, dominated by iron foundries and crowded tenement houses where the workers and their families rest. These are places where those who don't follow the 'status quo' often vanish without a trace. Workers quietly disappear, strange machinery operates long after businesses close, and residents avoid discussing what happens after dark. Here the use of Unique Flesh Machinery is done as a method to quicken the industrial processes. The machinery isn't powered by electricity. It's powered by living biological material infused with Veil energy. Nobody knows exactly where the material comes from. Workers aren't allowed into certain factory levels. Evidence discovered here suggests Ashley was investigating illegal experiments involving Veil exposure. The detective must navigate dangerous factories and hidden tunnels while determining whether the disappearances are connected to the murder or part of a much larger conspiracy.
- **The Velvet Quarter:** The Wealthy part of the city, grand art deco theaters, high end speakeasies, and opulent manors where the elite secret societies (influential politicians, business owners, and secret societies) of both man and outer entities make deals with one another beyond the understandings of others. Ashley's notebook contains several references to meetings held within this district, suggesting that someone among Ravenwatch's elite wanted her investigation silenced.
- **Saint Hope's Asylum & Morgue:** the bleak stone facility perched on the edge of the city, Serving as ground zero for medical studies of 'flesh machinery' and further research into cosmic induced medical and mental issues. Ashley Stern's autopsy report is stored within the facility, but portions of the report have mysteriously disappeared. As the detective searches the hospital, they uncover decades of classified patient records documenting people whose perception changed after encountering The Veil.

- The Miskatonic precinct (Precinct 13): The overworked and smoke-filled police station filled with corrupt officers, enforcing what they themselves think is law. Precinct 13 serves as the detective's headquarters throughout the investigation. Initially, it appears to be one of the few trustworthy places remaining in Ravenwatch. However, as the detective uncovers more evidence and their perception evolves, fellow officers begin revealing unsettling eldritch forms hidden beneath their human appearance. The precinct becomes a central location where players organize evidence, interview suspects, and slowly discover that corruption may exist much closer than they ever imagined.

Travel

- District-to-district (fast travel): Players travel between Ravenwatch's districts using taxis or the city's aging subway system. Taxis provide a safe and reliable means of transportation, while the subway offers faster travel at greater risk. Certain subway stations become heavily influenced by The Veil, causing spatial distortions, supernatural encounters, and hidden investigative opportunities. Choosing when and how to travel can reveal optional evidence or expose the detective to additional danger.
- On-foot Exploration: Each district is explored on foot, navigation is strictly through a topdown perspective. Mainly using tight alleys, backdoors and fire escapes in order to evade hostile enemies. Navigation emphasizes 3D spatial audio, environmental narration, the detective's mobility cane, and guidance from their companion rather than traditional visual markers. Sounds such as distant conversations, dripping water, police sirens, barking dogs, and footsteps help players orient themselves and locate important clues.

Scale

The game would use a 1:1 human scale during gameplay, attempting to keep the focus on the claustrophobic environments and the investigation aspects. Distance will be physically consistent but areas high with eldritch influence will seem stretched and warped to scale, hallways feeling miles long and small rooms feeling like ballrooms.

Objects

- Investigative clues: Ledger notes, occult symbols etched into stone or wood, case files and other forms of potential evidence.
- Consumables and Survival: Items that restore your sanity when investigating or asking certain npc's questions
- Eldritch Artifacts: A whistle that summons your trusty eldritch, seeing canine companion, a walking cane and a notepad that writes itself.

Weather; Day and Night

- Weather: A continuous, cold downpour that makes the cobblestone streets slick & a nearly everpresent fog that rolls off the bay area.

Time

Time will work as a sort of "how long can you spend within one area before you're forced to leave or possibly restart the area. Working in a similar sense to the Persona games or *The Legend of Zelda: Majora's Mask*, the idea is to give a sense of urgency for a crime before the potential culprit is able to get away.

The World Layout

Overview

The world layout of *The Eldritch Darkness* is designed as a concentric hub system where order dissolves into madness the deeper the player ventures. At the macro level, Ravenwatch is structured around a central, relatively stable city core that radiates outwards into increasingly warped districts that culminate into the shifting, non-euclidean wilderness beyond the city limits.

World Layout Detail #1

Ravenwatch is constructed as stacked physical layers that reflect its social and cosmic hierarchy, The heights, the street level, and the Underbelly.

- The Heights(Upper level): Towering art deco skyscrapers, glass roofed observatories, elevated railway lines where the city's elites gather. While these areas are visually pristine, they harbor esoteric cults and Eldritch god playing as mortals for their own amusement
- Street Level: The rainsoaked pavement, alleyways, storefronts, and Jazz clubs. This is where most of the gameplay will take place.
- The Underbelly: The vast subterranean network consisting of victorian-era sewer Systems, abandoned subway tunnels, flooded catacombs, and ancient pre-human ruins underneath the city.

World Layout Detail #2

The geography in Ravenwatch is not completely fixed. The layout responds to the level of cosmic corruption within a given area.

- Anchor Location: Key landmarks like a police station, central library or the players Investigation agency will remain static and will serve as safe places (In a similar fashion to the safe rooms in the *Resident Evil* franchise).
- Fluctuation Zones: High cosmic influence spaces will feature spatial distortions, meaning that you could end up in a completely different location then intended. An example is walking through an alleyway and appearing inside of a restaurant you might have had your mind on.
- Map Decay: For certain cases, the closer your deadline approaches the more the player's limited vision will and other senses will get warped. Simple silhouettes of people or objects will look distorted or be seen as completely different objects as the player character becomes increasingly stressed.

Game Characters

Overview

Player Character: The main playable character will be created to the players specification.

Companions: Players will be able to select an animal companion. There will be a few different choices, ranging from a dog, cat, bird, etc.

Victim: Ashley Stern was a 22-year-old journalism student at New York University with an insatiable curiosity and a determination to uncover the truth, no matter the cost. Intelligent, compassionate, and fiercely independent, Ashley had recently become obsessed with investigating a series of unexplained disappearances and strange occurrences throughout Ravenwatch. What began as a routine research project gradually led her to discover evidence of The Veil, a hidden force concealing the city's true nature.

In the weeks leading up to her death, Ashley became increasingly secretive, documenting her findings in journals, photographs, and audio recordings while confiding only fragments of her discoveries to those closest to her. She was murdered inside her apartment before she could expose what she had learned, leaving behind a trail of clues scattered throughout the city.

Players gradually piece together Ashley's life through interviews with family, friends, neighbors, and suspects, as well as by exploring her apartment and recovering the evidence she left behind. Although she is never seen alive, Ashley's personality, relationships, and determination remain at the heart of the investigation, making her more than just the victim, she becomes the driving force behind the detective's search for the truth.

Other characters: A non comprehensive list of other characters is included below. Everyone is a potential suspect!

Witnesses

Anita Caldwell: Ashley Stern's elderly neighbor who lives directly across the hall. Anita is warm, talkative, and always seems to know what's happening in the apartment building. She claims to have heard strange noises the night of Ashley's murder but struggles to remember specific details. As the detective's perception changes, Anita is revealed to be a large, fur-covered eldritch creature resembling Bigfoot. Despite her intimidating appearance, Anita is kind-hearted and genuinely wants Ashley's killer brought to justice.

Fred Holloway: Fred lives in the apartment next to Ashley's and was known to have an unrequited romantic interest in her. His awkward behavior and inconsistent statements quickly make him a person of interest. Beneath his ordinary appearance, Fred's true form is that of a towering green cyclops. Although suspicious, his feelings toward Ashley may not be as sinister as they first appear.

Professor Grant Felt: Grant is a respected professor of history at the local University who lives on the opposite side of Ashley's apartment. Quiet, intelligent, and rarely seen outside his home, he spends most of his time researching ancient civilizations and forbidden mythology. Ashley frequently visited him while researching local folklore, making him one of the few people aware of her investigation into The Veil. Whether he is protecting Ashley's discoveries or hiding his own involvement remains uncertain.

Peyton Brooks: A young woman who lives across the street from Ashley's apartment. While walking her dog on the night of the murder, Peyton witnessed someone fleeing the building moments after the crime occurred. Her testimony provides one of the investigation's earliest leads, though the detective soon discovers that what she saw may not be what actually happened.

Family/Friends

Meagan Stern: The victim's sister. She has flown into town for the funeral and to answer questions for the investigator. She will provide lots of vital info regarding Ashley's daily life.

Alice Stern: The victim's mother. She lives 30 minutes from Ashley's apartment. She is distraught, and willing to do whatever she can to help with the investigation.

Frank Stern: The victim's father. He lives with Alice. He is also distraught, and offers to do whatever is necessary to help catch the killer.

Derek Maxwell: The victim's boyfriend, and prime suspect. The player will conduct multiple interviews with this character throughout the game. Is he hiding something?

Carol Bennett: The victim's best friend. They have been inseparable since they became friends in their senior year of high school. A key witness.

Other Suspects

Bartholomew: A quiet man who works the late shift at the Bluewater Bay docks. Peyton identifies him as the individual she saw running from Ashley Stern's apartment building shortly after the murder, making him one of the detective's earliest suspects. During questioning, Bartholomew claims he was simply passing through the neighborhood on his way home, but his nervous demeanor and inconsistent timeline raise suspicion.

As the detective's perception deepens through exposure to The Veil, Bartholomew's true appearance is gradually revealed, a small pink eldritch being with curved horns and a forked tail. Despite his unsettling form, the investigation eventually reveals that Bartholomew was not fleeing the murder scene because he committed the crime, but because he witnessed something he was too frightened to report.

Brandon Pierce: A local drug supplier whose number was found written down in Ashley's apartment. What is the connection here?

Captain Elias Graves: The commanding officer overseeing Ashley Stern's murder investigation. Calm, experienced, and highly respected within Precinct 13, Graves serves as the detective's mentor throughout much of the game, reviewing evidence, assigning leads, and offering guidance whenever the investigation reaches a dead end. As the case progresses, however, inconsistencies begin appearing in police reports, evidence mysteriously disappears, and witnesses become increasingly difficult to locate. The detective must eventually confront the possibility that someone within the police department is manipulating the investigation from the inside.

Creating a Character

Players begin the game by creating their own detective through a fully accessible character creation system. Players can customize body type, skin tone, facial features, hairstyle, hair color, eye color, clothing, voice, and other cosmetic features, or choose from several preset detectives or generate a random character. Every option is fully narrated, allowing visually impaired players to customize their detective independently through descriptive audio.

At the start of the game, the detective appears entirely human. As they become increasingly exposed to **The Veil**, subtle distortions begin affecting their perception, causing them to catch brief glimpses of hidden features in themselves and those around them. These moments reinforce the game's central theme that appearances are often an illusion and that the truth lies beneath the surface.

Enemies & Monsters

Players encounter corrupt officials, cult members, criminals, and supernatural beings that stand in the way of the investigation. Encounters focus on stealth, exploration, and escape rather than combat.

As exposure to The Veil increases, characters gradually reveal their hidden eldritch forms. However, appearances are deceiving, not every monster is an enemy, and not every human is innocent.

User Interface

Overview

The user interface for *The Eldritch Darkness* is designed with accessibility and immersion as its primary goals. The interface remains clean and uncluttered, allowing players to focus on exploration, investigation, and environmental storytelling. Rather than relying heavily on visual indicators, the game communicates important information through narrated menus, spatial audio, vibration feedback, and optional high-contrast visual elements. Every option will be narrated, and every movement will be guided by audio and vibrations.

As the detective investigates Ashley Stern's murder, the interface also reflects the growing influence of The Veil, subtly changing alongside the player's perception without interfering with gameplay.

Investigation Interface

The Investigation Interface acts as the detective's primary source of information throughout the game. Players can review collected evidence, witness statements, crime scene photographs, maps, and case notes through the enchanted notebook. Evidence is automatically organized by category and can be linked together to identify relationships between suspects, locations, and events.

All notebook menus are fully narrated, allowing visually impaired players to review clues independently. As new evidence is discovered, the notebook automatically updates and highlights unresolved leads, ensuring players always have a clear understanding of their current investigation.

Navigation & Accessibility Interface

Navigation is designed to minimize dependence on visual information while remaining useful for all players. Important objects, doors, interactive items, and environmental hazards are communicated through directional audio, controller vibration, narrated descriptions, and the detective's mobility cane. Fuzzy, the detective's trusted companion, can also assist by locating important clues, guiding the player toward objectives, and warning of nearby danger.

Players can customize numerous accessibility settings, including narration speed, subtitle size, high-contrast mode, controller vibration intensity, audio cue volume, and menu narration. These features ensure the game remains fully playable for both sighted and visually impaired players while preserving the intended investigative experience.

Items

Overview

Items in *The Eldritch Darkness* are designed to support investigation, navigation, and evidence collection rather than combat. As a detective, the player relies on specialized investigative tools to examine crime scenes, interview witnesses, and uncover clues surrounding Ashley Stern's murder. While many items are based on equipment commonly used by detectives, several possess eldritch properties connected to The Veil, blending traditional investigative work with supernatural elements.

Every item serves a practical purpose throughout the investigation, encouraging players to observe their surroundings, revisit locations, and piece together evidence rather than relying on weapons or combat mechanics.

The Enchanted Notebook

One of the detective's most valuable tools is an enchanted notebook obtained through a mysterious pact. Because the detective is nearly blind, the notebook automatically records conversations, transcribes interviews, and organizes evidence as it is discovered. Rather than requiring the detective to manually write notes, the notebook documents important details on its own, ensuring that no valuable information is overlooked.

The notebook can read its contents aloud or communicate them directly within the detective's mind, allowing players to review witness statements, clues, objectives, and case files without relying on visual text. As the investigation progresses, the notebook also links related pieces of evidence together, helping players identify contradictions, establish timelines, and uncover new leads.

Mobility Cane

The detective's mobility cane serves as both a navigation aid and an investigative tool. Similar to a traditional long cane used by individuals with visual impairments, it allows the detective to safely explore Ravenwatch by detecting obstacles, changes in terrain, staircases, doorways, and interactive objects.

Different surfaces produce distinct audio cues when struck, helping players identify their surroundings through sound. The cane can also be used to examine suspicious objects, locate hidden passages, or carefully inspect unfamiliar environments before moving forward. As exposure to The Veil increases, the cane occasionally detects subtle disturbances that ordinary senses cannot perceive, providing hints toward hidden evidence or supernatural activity without revealing too much.

Companion Whistle

The Companion Whistle allows the detective to summon their trusted seeing companion, Fuzzy, whenever assistance is needed. Fuzzy serves as both a guide and investigative partner, helping the detective safely navigate Ravenwatch's streets, buildings, and crime scenes. When called, Fuzzy can lead the detective toward objectives, locate hidden clues, track scents left behind at crime scenes, and alert the player to nearby hazards or suspicious individuals.

As the detective's perception evolves through exposure to The Veil, Fuzzy becomes increasingly valuable. The companion is often able to sense supernatural disturbances long before the detective can perceive them, warning the player of hidden dangers or guiding them toward evidence concealed by The Veil. Because Fuzzy's instincts are unaffected by illusion, the whistle becomes one of the detective's most reliable tools throughout the investigation.

Musical Scores and Sound Effects

Overview

Sound is one of the core pillars of *The Eldritch Darkness*. Rather than simply providing atmosphere, audio serves as a primary gameplay mechanic that supports navigation, investigation, storytelling, and accessibility. Because the game is designed to be fully playable for both sighted and visually impaired players, 3D spatial audio, environmental sound cues, voice acting, and music work together to immerse players in Ravenwatch while guiding them through each investigation.

As the detective uncovers more about Ashley Stern's murder and becomes increasingly exposed to The Veil, the game's audio gradually evolves. Ordinary sounds become distorted, voices carry hidden whispers, and familiar environments take on an increasingly unsettling presence, reflecting the detective's changing perception of reality.

Musical Score

The musical score blends orchestral horror, ambient electronic textures, and subtle jazz influences inspired by the city's Art Deco setting. During exploration and investigation, the soundtrack remains minimal, allowing players to focus on environmental sounds and dialogue. As danger approaches or major discoveries are made, the music gradually becomes more intense through deep string arrangements, atmospheric drones, and distorted choral elements, creating a slow-building sense of unease rather than relying on sudden jump scares.

Each district features its own musical identity, helping players recognize locations through sound while reinforcing the unique atmosphere of Ravenwatch.

Sound Design

Sound design is central to both gameplay and immersion. Players use 3D spatial audio to navigate the environment, locate evidence, identify nearby characters, and detect potential hazards. Environmental sounds such as rainfall, distant train whistles, echoing footsteps, creaking floorboards, crashing waves, humming machinery, and barking dogs help players build a mental map of each location while providing important navigational cues.

Dialogue is equally important to the investigation. As exposure to The Veil increases, voices gradually change. Conversations begin sounding normal but slowly develop layered whispers, echoes, and distorted undertones that subtly expose lies, hidden emotions, or information that characters are unwilling to reveal. These audio changes reinforce the game's central theme that appearances, and even words, cannot always be trusted.

Accessibility is integrated into every aspect of the audio design. Players can customize narration speed, dialogue volume, subtitle settings, spatial audio intensity, controller vibration, and environmental sound levels, ensuring the investigative experience remains engaging and fully accessible without compromising immersion.

Single-Player Game

Overview

The Eldritch Darkness is a single-player, narrative-driven detective game that combines psychological horror, investigation, and accessibility-focused gameplay. Players assume the role of a nearly blind detective tasked with solving the murder of Ashley Stern, a journalism student whose investigation into Ravenwatch's hidden secrets ultimately cost her life. Through exploration, interviews, evidence collection, and deductive reasoning, players gradually uncover a conspiracy surrounding The Veil, a mysterious force concealing the city's true nature.

Rather than relying on combat, the game emphasizes observation, critical thinking, and player choice. Every clue, conversation, and decision contributes to the investigation and influences how the story unfolds.

Investigation & Exploration

The core gameplay revolves around investigating crime scenes, interviewing witnesses and suspects, collecting evidence, and connecting clues to uncover the truth behind Ashley Stern's murder. Players freely explore Ravenwatch's districts using environmental audio, narration, and guidance from their companion, Fuzzy. As the investigation progresses, previously inaccessible locations, hidden evidence, and new dialogue options become available, encouraging players to revisit earlier areas with fresh perspective.

Player Choice & Consequences

Players must carefully decide how to spend their time, which leads to pursue, and whom to trust. Witnesses may become unavailable, evidence can disappear, and suspects continue their lives as the investigation unfolds. Choices made during interviews and throughout the investigation influence character relationships, available evidence, and ultimately determine how much of the truth the detective uncovers before confronting the murderer.

Story

Players investigate the murder of Ashley Stern, a journalism student found dead in her apartment under mysterious circumstances. What initially appears to be a straightforward homicide soon reveals connections to a hidden conspiracy spanning Ravenwatch's most influential citizens. Ashley had been investigating a series of disappearances, secret organizations, and unexplained events that all pointed toward The Veil, a supernatural force concealing the city's true reality.

As the detective follows Ashley's trail, exposure to The Veil gradually changes their perception. Familiar people begin revealing hidden eldritch forms, voices carry unsettling whispers, and the city itself becomes increasingly distorted. The detective must determine what is real, uncover the truth behind Ashley's investigation, and identify the person responsible for silencing her before the conspiracy claims another victim.

A complete story outline, character biographies, and narrative progression can be found in the appendix of this Game Design Document.

Hours of Gameplay

The main story is designed to provide approximately 6–8 hours of gameplay. Players who choose to fully explore Ravenwatch, complete optional investigations, uncover hidden evidence, and experience multiple endings can expect additional replay value. Different choices, investigative paths, and conclusions encourage players to revisit the game to discover information they may have missed during previous playthroughs.

Victory Conditions

Players complete *The Eldritch Darkness* by solving the murder of Ashley Stern through careful investigation, evidence collection, and logical deduction. Throughout the game, players must examine crime scenes, interview witnesses and suspects, connect pieces of evidence, and uncover the conspiracy surrounding The Veil.

While the investigation can lead to multiple endings, there is only one true murderer. The player's choices determine how much of the truth is uncovered, which evidence is collected, and how the detective ultimately responds to the conspiracy. Depending on the player's decisions, they may expose the murderer and reveal the truth behind The Veil, preserve the city's secrets, fail to gather sufficient evidence, or unknowingly allow the conspiracy to continue.

Successfully achieving the true ending requires players to thoroughly investigate Ravenwatch, uncover critical evidence, correctly identify the murderer, and make the choices necessary to expose both the crime and the hidden forces behind it.

Single-Player Game

Overview

Although *The Eldritch Darkness* includes visual character models for sighted players, characters are primarily presented through voice acting, spatial audio, environmental narration, and expressive dialogue. Every character is designed to have a unique vocal identity, allowing players to recognize individuals through their voices, speech patterns, and mannerisms rather than relying solely on appearance.

As the detective's perception changes throughout the investigation, the way characters are presented gradually evolves, reinforcing the mystery surrounding The Veil.

Audio Character Identity

Each major character has a distinct voice, personality, and speech pattern that helps players identify them naturally during conversations. Spatial audio allows players to determine where characters are standing, while vocal performances communicate emotion, deception, and urgency. Rather than relying on visual expressions, the game uses tone of voice, pacing, breathing, pauses, and ambient sound to convey each character's emotional state.

As exposure to The Veil increases, voices begin to subtly change. Conversations that once sounded ordinary gradually develop layered whispers, echoes, and distorted undertones that hint at hidden truths without immediately revealing them. These changes support both the game's horror atmosphere and its central theme that not everything is as it first appears.

Optional Visual Transformation

For sighted players, characters are rendered in a semi-realistic Art Deco-inspired style that complements Ravenwatch's 1940s aesthetic. At the beginning of the game, every character appears completely human. As the detective uncovers more of the city's secrets, subtle visual distortions begin appearing before eventually revealing each character's hidden eldritch form.

These visual transformations are entirely optional to understanding the story. Important narrative information is always communicated through dialogue, narration, sound design, and gameplay, ensuring that visually impaired players receive the same information and experience as sighted players. The visuals enhance the atmosphere but never provide clues that cannot also be discovered through audio.

Annotated Bibliography

Savaglio, R., et al. "An Accessible Version of the Foodbot Factory Serious Game for Nutrition Education." *IEEE Transactions on Games, Games, IEEE Transactions on, IEEE Trans. Games*, vol. 17, no. 1, Mar. 2025, pp. 181–95. *EBSCOhost*, <https://doi.org/10.1109/TG.2024.3414657>.

In this article, a group of professors work to make another version of a popular game that is playable by those with visual impairments. The introduction to this article demonstrates again the gap in the market for games that are accessible by players with visual impairments. The vast majority of games are not designed with accessibility in mind. They use a similar method as we want to employ for our game. They design a new version of Foodbot Factory that is playable with audio only. This article demonstrates that there is still a major hole in the market for not only games that depict visual impairments, but for games that are playable by the visually impaired.

Sky LaRell Anderson. *Ability Machines : What Video Games Mean for Disability*. Indiana University Press, 2024. *EBSCOhost*, research.ebsco.com/plink/22ed84cf-a568-3713-873d-d1edcfc8aee9.

In this book, we specifically examined section 3 on depicting ability. In the beginning of this section, there is an interview with game design students on how games can better depict or help people understand blindness. They discuss a game in which the player/main character has no vision or very limited vision, and must navigate mostly with audio cues. This demonstrates clearly the gap that our game is trying to meet. There are very few games that have attempted to help the players understand what it is like to be blind, or that are designed to be accessible for blind players.